

CHARACTERISATION

Bringing a character to life



1 What is it?

Characterisation

Characterisation is how a writer builds a **believable, distinct character** — through what they say, do, think, and how others react to them.

speech + action + thought = a real person

2 See it in action

Through speech

"I don't need anyone's help," she snapped, before quietly asking for it anyway.

Through action

He folded his napkin into a perfect square — even now, everything had to be in order.

Through others' reactions

The room fell silent whenever he walked in.

Through thought

She hated herself for hoping he'd notice.



You got this!

Look for a **small, specific action or gesture** rather than a direct description of personality — that's usually where a writer is characterising most carefully.

FUN FACT

Writers often give a character one small, consistent physical habit (a nervous laugh, a particular phrase) specifically so readers can recognise them instantly, even without a name attached to their dialogue.

3 Why writers use it

Characterisation helps writers: make a reader care about what happens to someone, create characters that feel real and contradictory rather than flat, and let personality drive the plot instead of just narrating events.

The best characterisation often shows a gap between what a character **SAYS** and what they **DO** — that contradiction is usually where the most interesting, believable detail lives.

4 Where you'll spot it

Novels & short stories

A small, specific habit or gesture (twisting a ring, avoiding eye contact) tells a reader more than a paragraph of description.

Film & TV

Actors build character through small physical choices — the same tool writers use with action and gesture on the page.



Watch out!

Don't just tell the reader a character's personality ("he was kind and brave") — **SHOW** it through what they choose to say or do in a specific moment.



Good spot!

Ask what a character's **dialogue reveals** that they might not even realise about themselves — the gap between what they say and what they mean is rich for analysis.

5 Quick recap

Built through speech,
action, thought

Shown through others'
reactions

Makes a character feel
real



Keep going!

Try introducing a character using only one line of dialogue and one action — no description at all — see how much personality still comes through.